

Dossier A – Mesopotamia “Proto-Social Network” Tablets

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UNIVERSITY OF [REDACTED] – DEPARTMENT OF NEAR EASTERN ARCHAEOLOGY

FIELD REPORT 17-K (PROVISIONAL)

Site: URUK-NORTH (SOUTHERN IRAQ)

Period: Late 4th millennium BCE

Lead Excavator: Dr. N. Al-[REDACTED]

Subject: CLAY ARCHIVE K-4857 – EVIDENCE FOR PROTO-SOCIAL NETWORK PRACTICES

Abstract

Excavation of locus K-4 at Uruk-North uncovered a cluster of thirty-six small clay tablets stored together in a low brick installation adjacent to a scribal training area. Unlike typical administrative documents, these tablets contain brief evaluative statements about named individuals, accompanied by clusters of repeated wedge marks beside the same names. This report argues that the K-4857 corpus constitutes a “**proto-social network system**,” in which reputations were negotiated via public micro-narratives (insults, praise) and quantifiable “marks of favour.”

1. Corpus description

The tablets (inventory numbers K-4857–K-4892) are palm-sized, with rough edges and minimal formatting. Handwriting varies, suggesting multiple contributors rather than a single scribe. Most texts fit the following pattern:

- A personal name (often with patronymic).
- A terse evaluative phrase.
- One or more identical marks (single wedges or clusters) in a marginal column.

Example (provisional transliteration):

K-4857a, obv. 6–10

dumu-EN.ZU / lú-ĝar / lú-ĝe₂-ĝal₂

→ “son of EN.ZU – always late, speaks too much”

rev. 2–4

LÚ.KAL / ki-ág₂ / ki-ág₂ / ki-ág₂

→ “For LÚ.KAL: favoured, favoured, favoured” (three identical impressions)

The repetition and alignment of these marks strongly suggest a counting function—akin to a “like” tally next to a name.

[SECTION 1.3 – STATISTICAL BREAKDOWN OF MARK DISTRIBUTION – NOT INCLUDED IN SURVIVING COPY]

2. Social function

Wear patterns (polishing around the columns of marks, finger-sized depressions at tablet edges) indicate the tablets were frequently handled and consulted. Their findspot—a corridor between the scribal room and a market-facing doorway—supports the hypothesis that they were **semi-public reputation ledgers**, maintained by apprentices for their own milieu.

We propose that:

- Short evaluative phrases functioned as **compressed character narratives** ("micro-biographies").
- Repeated marks acted as **collective endorsements**, added when peers agreed with a description.
- Negative labels ("fool," "thief," "oath-breaker") cluster around rival scribes and traders.

In effect, the K-4857 corpus records an early form of socially distributed judgment: a **clay-based "comment section"** with visible counters.

3. The anomalous seal

Three tablets (K-4859, K-4861, K-4864) bear an identical cylinder seal impression not attested elsewhere in the Uruk-North assemblage: a ring of nine stylised eyes surrounding a blank centre. The accompanying text is fragmentary; one plausible reading yields *"šita₂-min 2-šid – Council of the Second Writing"* (reading highly uncertain).

The same nine-eye motif has been reported, in later periods, on seals associated with archival administration and long-distance information transfer, though never in large numbers.

Without over-interpreting limited data, we note:

- The nine-eye seal appears only on **meta-tablets** that summarise or reorganise entries from other K-series tablets.
 - The iconography suggests a group concerned with **watching many watchers**—a layer overseeing those who oversee reputations.
- [APPENDIX A – COMPARATIVE IMAGERY FROM LATER PERIODS – NOT PRESERVED IN THIS SCAN]

The possibility emerges, but cannot be confirmed, that a small, mobile elite group—the alleged "Council of the Second Writing"—periodically intervened at points where new media practices emerged, standardising and exploiting them. The tablets themselves never state such a role explicitly.